

The Farm Household Allowance (FHA) program provides assistance to commercial-scale farmers and their partners who are experiencing financial hardship for any reason.

The program provides eligible farmers and their partners with a package of assistance that includes:

- up to 4 years of fortnightly income support (in every 10-year period)
- ancillary allowances such as Pharmaceutical Allowance, Telephone Allowance, Rent Assistance and Remote Area Allowance and a Health Care Card
- a professional financial assessment of the farm business (worth up to \$1,500)
- funding to help develop skills, access training and pay for professional advice (up to \$10,000 per person)
- Regular tailored support of a case manager.

An [independent FHA review](#) was undertaken in 2018.

Eligibility

To qualify for FHA, you must meet eligibility requirements. Each application is assessed on a case-by-case basis and people should not self-assess

Eligibility consists of a list of qualifications, plus an assets test, and an income test.

To qualify you must:

- be a farmer
- be an Australian citizen or permanent resident
- be at least 16 years of age
- have a right or interest in land and use it for a farm enterprise - this includes leasing and sharefarmers but excludes farm workers.

Your farm must be:

- in Australia
- have a significant commercial purpose or character.
- In deciding whether your farm enterprise has a significant commercial purpose or character, a range of matters must be considered, including:
 - the way the farm enterprise is conducted
 - the size and scale of the farm enterprise
 - whether the revenue generated by the farm enterprise is, or is expected within a reasonable period to be, at least \$60,000 per year
 - available markets for produce of the farm enterprise
 - suitability of the land for the operation of the farm enterprise
 - financial arrangements, including capital requirements and operational costs
 - profitability of the farm enterprise and any matters that may have adverse impacts.

You must:

- contribute a significant part of your labour and capital to the farm enterprise (this may exclude some younger generation farmers in multi-generational family operations where they have not contributed any capital, and semi-retired or absent farmers who do not contribute significant labour to the farm business)
- enter into an activity agreement to make changes to improve your medium and long-term financial security (called a financial improvement agreement), or have one in place already.

Farmer's partners:

If you are not involved in the farm business operated by your partner, you can apply as a farmer's partner

You cannot receive FHA if you:

- receive other pensions or social security benefits and are not prepared to give them up
- have already received the payment for 4 years (in the 10-year period)
- do not meet the criteria in the legislation, including income and assets tests.

Read the detail in the [FHA factsheets](#) or the [FHA guidelines](#).

Need help?

You can get help to understand and apply for Farm Household Allowance. Specially trained staff are available on the Farmer Assistance hotline at Services Australia, call 132 316 between 8am and 5pm, Monday to Friday.

You can also talk to a Rural Financial Counsellor. It is a free service. They will evaluate your situation and let you know what you can apply for. Find your local service provider by visiting the [Rural Financial Counselling Service](#) webpage.

See all [drought and rural support](#) we provide.

Payments and support

You can get Farm Household Allowance for up to 4 years (1,460 days) at any time in a 10-year period. The first 10-year period ran between 1 July 2014 and 30 June 2024. The second 10-year period is from 1 July 2024 to 30 June 2034. FHA gives you time to improve your circumstances. You do not have to receive all payments in one go. You can stop and start your payment as many times as you like. Stopping and deferring your payments can save them up for future hardship. You will also receive ongoing support from your own:

- Farm Household Case Officer (FHCO)
- Rural Financial Counsellor (RFC) (if you choose).

Apply

FHA applications and payments are managed by Services Australia. Although the application process is rigorous, most people say it is worth it and that FHA made a positive difference to their financial situation.

Do you have questions? Call the Farmer Assistance hotline on 132 316 between 8am and 5pm, Monday to Friday.

[Learn more about Farm Household Allowance](#) or read the [FHA factsheets](#).

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/node/7311>